

Recentring Academics — Syllabus Redesign: FRENCH 40 The Contemporary Francophone World through Cinema

- **Course:** FRENCH 40, The Contemporary Francophone World through Cinema (Printemps 2026).
Course Head: Dr. Claire-Marie Brisson.
- **Source syllabus:** [inputs/syllabus/F26 Brisson Syllabus The Contemporary Francophone World through Cinema.pdf](#).
- **Date:** 2026-06-10

FRENCH 40 is conducted entirely in French and builds the engaged-classroom pillar into its structure: students "are expected to speak only in French during class," attendance is capped at three absences with escalating grade consequences, cell phones must be off and laptops are barred except for specified activities, and the design depends on "spontaneous exchange" and "real-time collaboration." With respect to grade differentiation, the course is well-positioned for a language course and resilient to AI by design: it grades to an explicit criterion-referenced percentage scale, places roughly 50% of the grade on verifiable in-class work that can differentiate on mastery (oral presentations 20%, evaluated on "depth of analysis and originality" and "fluency," plus three in-class written exams at 30%), and anchors its take-home writing in an in-class handwritten "atelier" draft introduced explicitly "to combat generative AI and online translation tools." The remaining differentiation gap is where the writing weight sits: the film critiques (20%) are graded 80% on take-home first and final drafts where translation and AI can reach the French, despite the atelier anchor, and the court métrage (15%) is a group production whose individual French contribution the syllabus does not separately grade.

1. Audit

Category	Current Syllabus	Guidance	Assessment
Attendance & participation	"You are allowed a maximum of three absences during the semester"; fourth absence reduces the final grade "by a sign (i.e., B+ → B)," fifth by another; "Three tardies to class will equal one absence." "A demonstrable effort in class activities and discussions determines your grade." Participation/preparation/homework is 15%.	Clear, communicated attendance and participation expectations on a stated standard (course policies)	A clear, strong attendance policy with stated consequences, reinforced by the French-immersion expectation. Participation is graded on "demonstrable effort," an effort standard; the syllabus does not state how stronger and weaker participation are distinguished.
In-class device use	"Cell phones must be off when you come into class, and laptops may not be used in class except for certain specified activities. The goal is for you to be present and focused for each class."	Limit or prohibit internet-enabled devices except when directed (course policies)	A clear device policy that matches the guidance directly.

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Generative-AI policy	Academic Honesty: "Use of translation software or sites such as Google Translate is likewise considered cheating and is not permitted." Atelier: "To combat generative AI and online translation tools, you will work on the first written draft during an in-class atelier... strictly prohibited from typing or using digital access or technology to craft your initial responses."	Clear, learning-objective-aligned AI policy made real by assignment design (course policies ; designing assignments)	The policy is made real by design: the atelier anchors writing in verifiable in-class work and translation tools are explicitly barred. Generative AI is named in the atelier rationale but not in the Academic Honesty section itself, and the take-home critique drafts and the court métrage script are not explicitly covered; a unified statement naming generative AI would close the gap.
Grade Weighting	Class participation/preparation/homework 15%, oral presentations 20%, film critique writing 20%, exams 30%, final project (court métrage) 15%.	Enough of the grade must rest on work that can differentiate on content/skill	About 50% (oral presentations 20% + exams 30%) is verifiable, in-class, high-ceiling work that can differentiate on mastery. The 20% film critiques are largely take-home; the 15% court métrage is group take-home; the 15% participation is effort-based. Substantial differentiating weight sits on verifiable work.
Grade Differentiation	Oral presentations evaluated on "Depth of analysis and originality of insights" and "Clarity, accuracy, and fluency of spoken French"; exams include "a	Assessments must span enough difficulty to differentiate at	The presentation and exam criteria leave headroom to resolve the

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	speaking or writing prompt"; participation: "A demonstrable effort... determines your grade."	the top, not top out for most strong students (discriminating-at-the-top)	strongest work; the 15% participation is effort-based and tends to top out. Differentiation rests on the presentations and exams, which holds if their top bands resolve genuine distinction; the court métrage phases are "assessed separately" and could compress if scored for completion.
Assessment Variety	Oral presentations, recorded and in-class discussion responses, in-class handwritten atelier drafts and revised written critiques, in-class written exams (listening, grammar/vocabulary, speaking or writing), and a group film (script, storyboard, production, reflective essay).	Mastery tested across varied formats	Mastery is tested across speaking, listening, writing, and audiovisual production, so the grade is not tied to a single mode of assessment.
Verifiability/AI-Resilience	Oral presentations "conducted entirely in French" in class; exams "held during class"; atelier first drafts handwritten in class with digital tools "strictly prohibited"; first and final critique drafts revised take-home; "recorded submissions uploaded to the course site"; court métrage script and production completed in small groups with a "public on-campus screening."	Work should be reliable evidence of the student's own unaided thinking; in-class components broaden the distribution (Harvard report , §III)	About 50% (presentations + exams), plus the atelier drafts and in-class discussion responses, is produced under supervision and verifiable. The first and final critique drafts (80% of the critique grade) and the court métrage script are take-home, where translation and AI reach the French; this is partly

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			mitigated by the atelier anchor and the in-person screening.
Cumulative assessment	The court métrage is "a final assessment of all course material," and the final unit is the "synthesis of all linguistic and technical skills to finalize the court métrage," ending in a public screening.	End-of-term assessment should be cumulative (designing assignments ; capstone)	The court métrage is a cumulative capstone that synthesizes the course's linguistic and cinematic skills and ends in a public screening, well aligned with capstone guidance. As a group production it is not an individually verifiable cumulative assessment.
Grading rigor & range	Explicit percentage scale: "94-100 A, 93-90 A-, 87-89 B+..." through "< 60 F."	Grade to explicit criterion-referenced standards (Sadler 2005); A reserved for "extraordinary distinction" (proposal)	An explicit criterion-referenced percentage scale, the recommended basis. The syllabus lists evaluation criteria for presentations and critiques but does not describe what distinguishes A-level from B-level work within them.
Feedback & consistency	"This course is taught by members of the Department" (multiple sections); critiques are graded in three stages "integrating instructor and, when applicable, peer feedback"; presentations and critiques carry listed evaluation criteria.	Norm grades across graders; rater training and calibration improve reliability (rubrics ; Jonsson & Svingby 2007)	The three-stage critique process with feedback is a strength for formative feedback. With multiple section instructors, consistency across sections matters; the shared scale

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			and listed criteria help, but the syllabus does not describe calibration on shared samples.

2. Recommended revisions

- **Shift more of the critique's differentiating weight onto the verifiable atelier, or add an in-class checkpoint.**
 - *Currently:* "Atelier Draft (20% of critique grade)" is in-class and handwritten; "First Draft (40%)" and "Final Draft (40%)" are revised take-home.
 - *Revise to:* raise the weight of the in-class atelier work, or add a short in-class element to the final critique (an in-class revision against a fresh prompt, or a brief oral defense of the critique's argument in French), so more of the critique grade rests on French produced under observation while the take-home drafts remain the site of feedback and growth ([full-range-task-design](#); [discriminating-at-the-top](#)).
- **Add an individually verifiable element to the court *métrage*.**
 - *Currently:* small groups "collaborate to write the script... and later film it," with the individual component being a 150–200 word reflective essay.
 - *Revise to:* attach a graded individual element anchored on each student's own French — for example, a short spoken introduction or question-and-answer at the public screening in which each member explains their contribution and the linguistic choices behind it — so the 15% reflects individual proficiency rather than only the group's film ([full-range-task-design](#); [discriminating-at-the-top](#)).
- **State a unified generative-AI policy covering all written French (see Section 3).**
 - *Currently:* translation software is barred in Academic Honesty, while generative AI is named only in the atelier rationale, and the take-home critique drafts and court *métrage* script are not explicitly addressed.
 - *Revise to:* name generative AI directly in the policy and state that it applies to the take-home critique drafts and the court *métrage* script, tying the rule to the atelier and in-class anchors that make it enforceable ([course policies](#); [designing assignments](#)).
- **Give the participation component a stated standard, or accept it as engagement.**
 - *Currently:* "A demonstrable effort in class activities and discussions determines your grade."
 - *Revise to:* state what distinguishes stronger from weaker participation (for example, the quality and accuracy of French contributions and engagement with peers' presentations) so the 15% measures communicative engagement on a stated standard, or accept it as an engagement floor and keep differentiation on the presentations and exams ([course policies](#); [rubrics](#)).
- **Publish what A-level work looks like and calibrate across sections.**
 - *Currently:* evaluation criteria are listed for presentations and critiques, but with multiple section instructors no calibration is described.
 - *Revise to:* for presentations, critiques, and exam free-response, describe A-level versus B-level work with the top band left open for genuine insight and fluency rather than a checklist,

distribute annotated exemplars, and hold a calibration session across section instructors before grades are set ([rubrics](#); [rubrics-differentiation](#); Jonsson & Svingby 2007).

3. A tailored generative-AI policy

The course already bans translation tools and anchors writing in the in-class atelier; the policy need only name generative AI directly and extend the same standard to every component where French is produced. Suggested syllabus language:

Generative AI in FRENCH 40.

- You may not use generative-AI tools or machine translation (for example ChatGPT, DeepL, or Google Translate) to produce or correct any French you submit, including the first and final drafts of your film critiques, your court métrage script, and your recorded discussion responses. Producing the French is the skill this course assesses, and the work must be your own.
- Your in-class atelier drafts, oral presentations, and exams are completed in class without these tools; they are where your own proficiency is assessed, and they anchor the take-home work to the French you can demonstrably produce.

If we have reason to believe submitted French was produced or corrected with these tools, we may ask you to discuss your work with us in French and, if warranted, refer the matter to the Honor Council.